reporter put it, “put a damper” on the visit, which Vajpayee cut short by a day.[209]

In what was seen as an attempt to soothe India, the official Chinese news agency subsequently said Beijing wanted “extensive development” of the relationship. That, it noted, could create the conditions for settling the border—which, in turn, could give impetus to the relationship.[210] But the damage was done. As Eric Gonsalves, a senior Indian diplomat on the visit, said, the invasion “had transformed a very useful visit into a somewhat disastrous episode.”[211]

Vajpayee tried to put a positive spin on the visit in parliament, stating that Chinese recognition of the importance of resolving the border issue was “not an insignificant step forward.” Moreover, Beijing had said its support for Indian insurgents was “a thing of the past.”[212] Gonsalves noted that the foreign minister and others were nonetheless “pilloried” in parliament.

The Indian government subsequently took a more assertive stance against Beijing’s action. It went from just calling for a Chinese withdrawal from Vietnam to Vajpayee labeling China an “aggressor.” He said its move was a “setback” to the Sino-Indian dialogue, and “a flagrant act of disrespect and discourtesy to India.”[213]

Carter wrote to Desai that he had advised Deng not to take military action.[214] However, American assessments noted that cross-party criticism in India of the US “acquiescing” in the Chinese move, and of “China [being] the new US policeman in Asia.”[215] Brzezinski instructed Christopher, due to visit India, to explain the US approach to his Indian counterparts. He wanted to seek their cooperation to contain the Sino-Vietnamese conflict and to encourage Indian calls for Soviet restraint. Reports that Delhi had urged Hanoi to withdraw from Cambodia emerged just before the deputy secretary of state met the Indian prime minister in Delhi. Desai’s concerns about China’s “foolish and high risk endeavor” were greater, but he worried about the overall danger of escalation in Southeast Asia.[216]

The US was similarly anxious. In March, the Carter administration expressed its concern to Deng and other Chinese leaders, cautioning that their continuing action would create an opportunity for Moscow in the region. It would also affect the Chinese modernization effort and shape opinion in the US about advancing the China relationship. The